Q. Dinesh Vijan has built a horror comedy universe and you are a key part of it. What is making the genre click with the masses?
Not every horror comedy is working. We have a herd mentality where if something works, people want to cash in on it. It is about a lot of things—writing is a very important aspect, as are giving the right balance and flavour of horror and comedy and telling a unique story in that world. It also boils down to the actors, because doing comedy is a gift, you either have it or you don't. Why is it working? Maybe because it's something new for the audience when you mix two genres. You also have an action comedy like *Bad Boys*, which also became a franchise. In India, it is horror comedy that is booming right now.

Q. What is it like acting in a horror comedy genre?
I see it from a broader perspective. There's comedy in tragedy somewhere. Chaplin based his whole career on that. A basic example is a guy walking down the street and slipping on a banana peel. It's painful for him, but it's funny for the audience to see. What I am doing in the Stree films is absolutely tragic—fighting and encountering ghosts—and I am shit scared. Of course, it comes down to how an actor takes the character forward. In *Stree 2*, we knew comedy was our main asset and I enjoy bringing my laughter bone out. I really had fun playing Bicky—he's a simpleton, a naïve and sweet boy who gets trapped in these surreal circumstances and how he comes out as a winner. I was improvising a lot on set, it happened more in this one than the first. I knew I can't be complacent and have to work extra hard. I wanted to have way more fun. Once you know a character, you can put it in any kind of situation and I will do what he has to do.

Q. *Stree 2* came after six years. Did it take time for the cast to reconnect?
It didn't take much time because I, Abhishek [Banerjee] and Apar [Aparshakti Khurana] have been friends since *Stree*. When you share that chemistry with your co-actors where you are feeding off each other, there's a lot of action-reaction going on; it's always fun to explore in that scenario.

Q. Sometimes actors know while shooting that what they are doing is something special. Did you have that during *Stree 2*?
Honestly, even when we were making Part 1, we didn't know it'd be such a huge success. We were just making it with the utmost sincerity. We knew Part 2 was a big responsibility because there was a huge fan base for *Stree* and we knew it'd get a lot of love. But none of us expected to achieve this kind of milestone; it is unreal for all of us. There's a lot of gratitude.

Q. Every actor wants to be part of a successful franchise and be remembered as a character. You have that with Bicky. How much has the character changed your life?
Bicky has given me a lot. *Stree* was my first major blockbuster. It has given my career a great push. I enjoy doing comedies that are relatable where people think 'I could be this guy'. With *Stree 2*, Bicky now has these superpowers, so I am excited to see what kind of a superhero he is going to be in *Stree 3*. I'd love to see a common man be a superhero.

fighting them, but it's funny for people to see." (*See interview.*) The genre's relative freshness, he feels, attracts audiences to it.

Stree 2 also profited from the actors' banter, the bouncing off of ideas and improvisation on set. "It's like college where *koi kisi ka saga nahin hai* [no one's partial to anyone]. The minute you go wrong, others will laugh," says Banerjee. "Apar has his one-liners, I can sometimes say very dumb things. Pankajji is a senior figure, so we have to behave in front of him sometimes, but he can also be very naughty. General loafer-ness aside, we are also very diligent professionals."

MEN BEHIND THE MONSTERS

Captaining the enterprise is director Amar Kaushik, son of a forest ranger who spent a chunk of his childhood in Arunachal Pradesh. (*Bhediya*, incidentally, is set and shot in Arunachal Pradesh.) Central to the horcom universe, Kaushik has helmed three popular films—*Stree* (2018), *Bhediya* (2022) and *Stree 2* (2024). His love for his films shows in his office at Santa Cruz. Be it the lifelike wolf made for *Bhediya*, or *Stree*'s famous plea, "*O Stree Kal Aana*", screaming from the wall in glaring red. Of his method, Kaushik says, "You can get inspired and be like, 'Wow, *kya film banayi hai*', but more important is to make it and tell it in your own way." All of Kaushik's three films have been co-produced by Dinesh Vijan's Maddock Films. Together, they have become the Marvel of the genre, creating a universe where key characters crisscross. *Munjya* is a part of it.

If there's one thread uniting these films, it is that the stories are rooted in Indian folklore and superstition. "In our culture, we have had asuras and rakshasas, and tantras and mantras have been part of our religious practice," says director Aditya Sarpotdar, whose *Munjya* draws from a Maharashtrian myth. "Horror narratives based on local folklore help them penetrate and resonate."

Kaushik isn't even a big fan of horror, and says he'd have to Google to find titles to sound "sophisticated". But it's his grandmother's tales that have stayed with him. "I treat horror as a fantasy world. Bodies coming out of the grave, *ek mahal mein koi akela* [being alone in a mansion]... that's not my scene," he says. Other than crafting fear-inducing set-pieces, what he likes is finding moments of respite. It explains